

## Cybercrime Case Study: UPI / Online Payment Fraud

Online payment fraud, especially through UPI, has become very common among college students in India. In this type of cybercrime, attackers trick users into sharing sensitive details or approving fraudulent payment requests.

A typical case begins when the victim receives a call, SMS, or message pretending to be from a bank official, delivery agent, or customer support executive. The attacker creates urgency, such as claiming a problem with the victim's account or offering a reward or refund. They then send a fake payment request or a malicious link.

The victim is asked to click the link or approve a "collect request" on their UPI app. Believing it to be genuine, the victim enters their UPI PIN. However, instead of receiving money, the amount is deducted from their account. In some cases, users are also tricked into sharing OTPs or installing screen-sharing apps, giving attackers full control.

Students and elderly people are often targeted because they may not be fully aware of such scams. The consequences include financial loss, stress, and in some cases, unauthorized access to bank accounts.

This highlights the importance of awareness and careful verification before making any online transaction.

### Stay Safe Online – Prevention Checklist

- Never share your **UPI PIN, OTP, or banking details** with anyone.
- Do not approve unknown **UPI collect requests**.
- Always verify the identity of the caller before taking any action.
- Avoid clicking on suspicious links received through SMS, email, or social media.
- Use official apps and websites for online transactions only.
- Enable **two-factor authentication (2FA)** wherever possible.

- Regularly check your bank statements and transaction history.
- Install apps only from trusted sources like Play Store or App Store.
- Be cautious of offers that seem too good to be true.
- For any fraud, immediately report at **cybercrime.gov.in** or call **1930 helpline**.

## **Reflection**

While researching about cybercrime, I was surprised to see how easily people fall victim to simple tricks like fake calls and UPI requests. The attackers mainly use psychological pressure and urgency to manipulate users into making mistakes. I realized that even a small action, like clicking on a link or sharing an OTP, can lead to serious financial loss.

This task made me more aware of the importance of online safety and being cautious while using digital platforms. One habit I will change is that I will never approve unknown payment requests or trust calls related to banking without proper verification. I will also ensure that I follow safe practices like using strong passwords and enabling security features in all my accounts.